



Windows Media Player from updating the information on a file from the internet. This is because an unpatched Windows Media Player provided with Windows 7 changes the file when it retrieves this information from the internet. For example, the audio information from the first few seconds of an mp3 file may be lost.

Use the search bar as a run bar

There is no run bar by default. However, when you click on start, the search field can be used for running programs. This process is made much faster in Windows 7, because you don't even have to type in the complete name of a file or program to open or run it.

Using program history

Windows 7 saves recently worked on documents in the start bar itself. These are not general documents in the 'documents' menu, but program specific documents. For example, the recently visited sites on Opera will show up in the sub menu for the Opera program, and can be launched from the start bar itself. Similarly, image editors, multimedia players, and practically every program will show up a sub menu with recently worked on items.

Using applications on the taskbar

Windows 7 replaces the space consuming application bars on the taskbar with icons. Hovering over the icon for an application shows a preview of the window. If there are multiple tabs in the application, then the preview will show all the tabs as separate windows. Hover over this preview to get the preview options. You can close tabs or windows from there. If you just hover over the preview and do nothing, all other windows will go transparent, letting you see the application in full screen. So, if you are writing an email, but a phone number is on a Notepad file in the background, you don't need to go through a series of minimise and maximise actions to have a peek at the notepad file. This is faster than [Alt]+[Tab] too. When an application opens up in the taskbar, right-click on it and click on pin this application to the taskbar. Like a dock in OS X, this application will remain here permanently. You can choose to unpin a program at any point of time. This feature takes away the need to go to the start menu for common applications.

Using window actions for managing windows

Click and drag the title-bar of any window to the top of the screen to maximise it. Click and

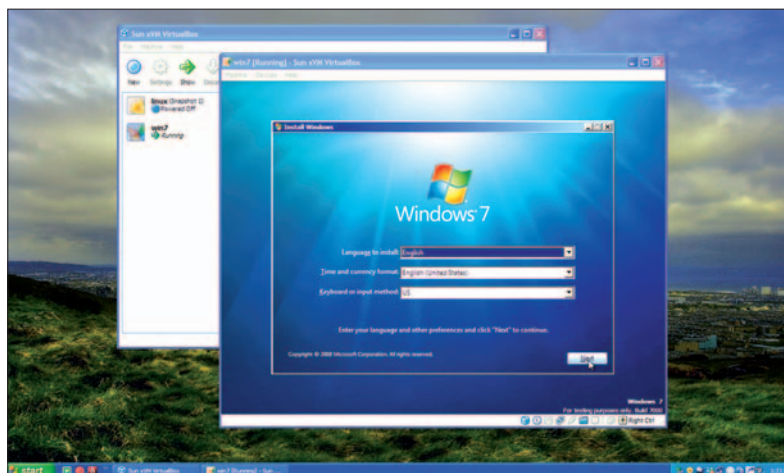
drag the top bar away from the top edge to restore the window. Click and drag the title-bar of any window to either side of the screen to make that window fit half the screen on the side to which you drag it. You can also use the [Windows] and the arrow keys to arrange the window. [Windows]+[Left] or [Windows]+[Right] will place the window on either side, [Windows]+Up will maximise and [Windows]+Down will minimise the window.

Cutting down the size of the taskbar

A significant difference is made by the size of the icons in the taskbar. By the standards of XP or Vista, they are huge. To change this, right-click on the taskbar, go to Properties > Taskbar and check use small icons.

Use VirtualBox to experience Windows 7

You do not need to partition your hard drive or use a spare computer to check out Windows 7. Just use a program called VirtualBox that emulates a virtual machine on your computer screen to install the operating system. Click New and enter a name for the machine. In the OS Type dialogue, choose Microsoft Windows as the operating system, and Other Windows as the version. Choose to make a hard drive of around 20 GB, but even 10 will suffice. In the Details window, mount the DVD image either by selecting an ISO, or the drive in which the DVD is in. Without this step, VirtualBox will not start the Windows 7 installation when the virtual machine starts up.



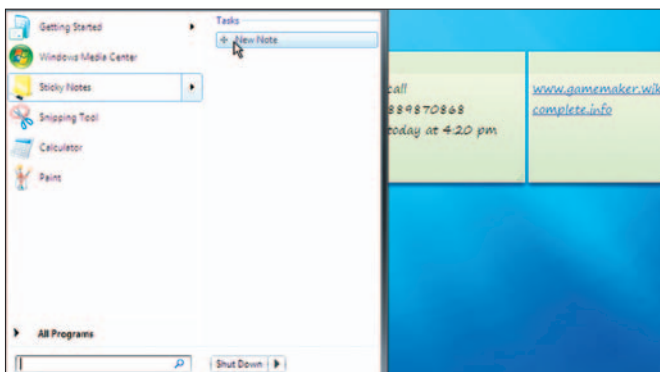
Use VirtualBox to install Windows 7 on earlier versions

Change network settings

The age old two computer icon for network connections has been replaced with a monitor and a cable icon. This will be one of the few icons on the system tray by default. Click on this icon, then click on Open network and Sharing center. This view will seem a little complicated. To get direct access to your connections for changing IP settings and the like, click on Change Adapter settings.

Use Sticky Notes

A great new feature in Windows 7 is the Sticky Notes. Start > Sticky Notes, and a small square appears on the screen exactly like a post it. Click on the plus sign to add a note, and drag the bottom right



Adding a Sticky Note to the desktop

corner to resize the note. Click on the cross to close and delete the note. Note that the text stored in the sticky notes cannot be saved, but the notes will survive restarts as long as you do not close them.

Use libraries

Libraries are a great way to navigate files on your computer. Say you have music stored across different hard drive partitions, and an external hard drive that is not always connected to the computer. Placing all the folders with music in them in the music library, will let you access the music files from essentially one folder. The files are not stored in the library, but the directory structure indexes the files and makes it accessible in this manner. You can also store the same files in different libraries using different library structures.